

Earn the platform. Don't announce it.

A 2–3 year strategy for AI-powered Customer Operations, diagnosed from why the original mid-market motion adopted slower than expected — not a broad platform pitch reformatted.

RECOMMENDATION leadership is right that the destination is a comprehensive Customer Operations Platform — but naming it doesn't earn it. Land one narrow, low-trust workflow; prove it; expand only after it's earned. Do not claim a validated ICP, a confirmed buyer, willingness to pay, or a proven moat.

Evidence base: 91 public evidence records (56 sources), 4 anonymized interviews, a four-vendor competitive teardown, and one bottom-up market analysis · Research status: evidence-limited; interview saturation and buyer validation not achieved.

01 · THE DIAGNOSIS

Why did the original motion stall?

The brief hands us a fact, not a footnote: mid-sized businesses (200–1,000 employees) were targeted first, and adoption was slower than expected. Four failure modes explain it, each traceable to evidence already on file.

FAILURE MODE	WHAT HAPPENED	EVIDENCE
1. Positioning trap	Sold as “another AI chatbot.” Every incumbent already claims AI agents, integrations, human handoff and governance.	Secondary research; competitive teardown
2. Access-and-trust veto	IT/security can kill a deal before the product is evaluated.	P03 — pilot capped to 2 queues, write-back disabled
3. Bundled-AI trap	Mid-market buyers compare a new vendor to the AI they already pay for.	Freshworks (S09): 36% stuck in pilots; 86% say AI adds workload
4. Workflow mismatch	Chat deflection was sold; the pain is back-office context work.	P01, P02, P04 describe manual cross-system reassembly

None of these four is a new discovery in isolation — pieces of each already existed across the research. What matters is treating them as one connected diagnosis that drives every later choice.

02 · Evidence base and method — four layers, never mixed

COUNT	MEANING
65	Source register entries: 64 external sources plus the assignment brief
56	Unique source IDs referenced by the 91 evidence records
91	Claim-level public evidence records with source URL, confidence and limitation
4	Interview records, maintained separately from public evidence

INTEGRITY RULE no review post is treated as an interview; no vendor statistic is treated as universal market fact; no paraphrased interview note is presented as a verbatim quote. The competitive teardown keeps its own register within the same discipline — V (vendor claim), R (review signal), I (interview), H (synthesis), U (unresolved).

Keep the size band. Narrow hard on who.

SEGMENT	PAIN EVIDENCE	WHY NOT
Enterprise	Most acute (P01 ~100–150 min/day; P02 4–6 hr waits)	P02 is regulated banking — maximizes the access veto. P01 is a multi-client BPO — no stack owner.
SMB / startups	Usually one consolidated tool	No helpdesk+CRM seam — no wedge to build on
Mid-market, filtered	The seam exists; buyer is reachable	Selected — avoids all three traps at once

WORKING SEGMENT B2B SaaS or technology-enabled services, ~51–1,000 employees, an established helpdesk and CRM/system of record, growing request volume, limited support-ops capacity.

Anti-personas — named, not implied

- Not regulated / financial services — P02 shows the compliance approval chain this triggers.
- Not single-system shops — no context to reassemble means no wedge.
- Not multi-client outsourced support operations (BPOs) — P01's stack changes by client; no one owns the access decision.

Primary persona

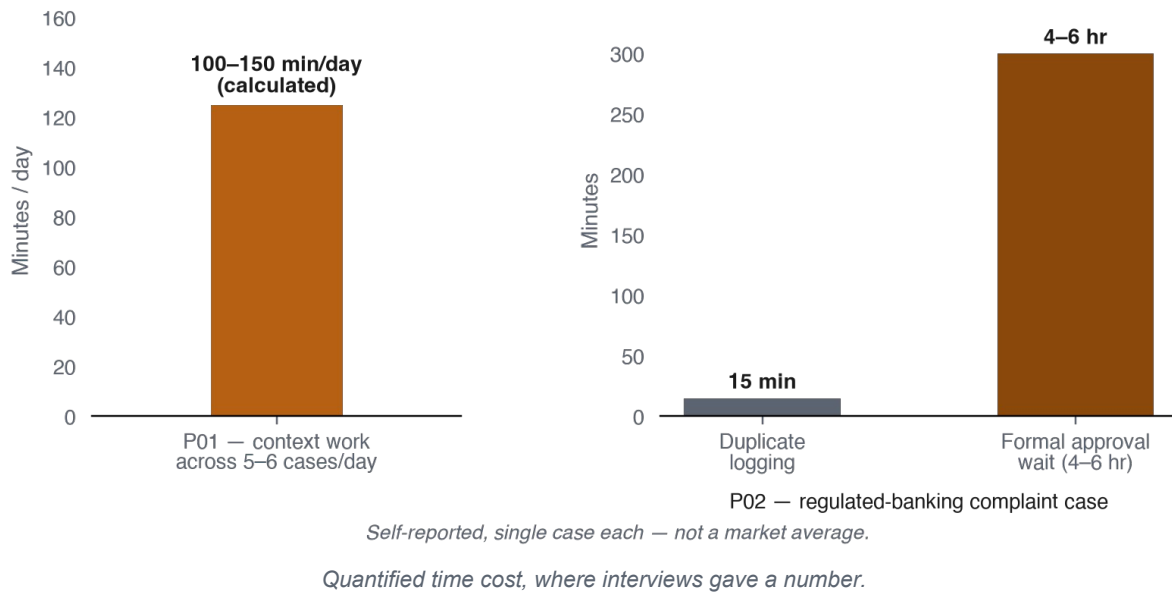
Frontline support/operations practitioner owning L1.5, escalation or exception work across several systems. Goal: give a correct update and move the case to resolution. Current friction: searches, copies, waits, and reconstructs history; handoff context isn't durable.

How the problem statement was derived

OBSERVED EVIDENCE	PATTERN	SAFE CONCLUSION
P01 + P04: complex escalations	Context reconstructed across helpdesk, CRM, chat, engineering systems	Context/handoff leads the workflow hypothesis (2 of 4)
P02: regulated banking complaints	15 min duplicate logging; 4–6 hr approval wait; audit split across systems	Audit-safe coordination matters in this case

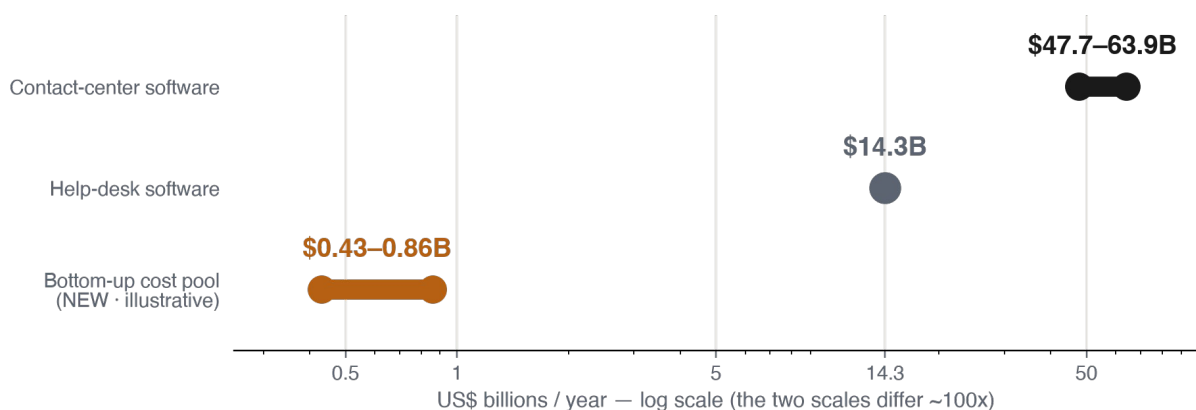
Four perspectives

P01 Enterprise outsourced support · frontline 5–6 difficult cases/day; 20–25 min context work per case. Strategic use: quantified context and handoff cost.	P02 Enterprise banking complaints · frontline 15 min duplicate logging; 4–6 hr formal approval wait. Strategic use: audit, approval and read-only constraints.
P03 Mid-market (~400) · application approval One-month pilot, 2 queues, write-back disabled. Strategic use: least-privilege, reversible pilot design.	P04 Mid-market B2B SaaS/services · frontline Manual Zendesk-to-Jira summary; warns against a duplicate system. Strategic use: second context/handoff case plus counter-evidence.
DIVERSITY AUDIT / LIMITATION 2 enterprise + 2 mid-market; 3 frontline + 1 application-approval stakeholder; no support manager or economic buyer interviewed. Sample is 4 of the requested 8–12 minimum — segment, buyer and adoption conclusions remain hypotheses.	



05 · MARKET OPPORTUNITY

Two honest ranges, plus one new estimate



SIGNAL	EVIDENCE	INTERPRETATION
Large adjacent category	Contact-center \$47.7–63.9B; help-desk \$14.3B	Real category, not one precise TAM
High workflow frequency	Vendor datasets span up to 1.2B tickets / 138M conversations	A pilot can observe repetition within weeks
Adoption–maturity gap	82% invested in AI; 10% report mature deployment	Reliability may matter more than basic AI access
Assist-first timing	Gartner: 73% forecast agent-assist by end-2025	Assist/shadow mode is the lower-risk landing motion
Security / readiness	51% say security delayed or limited AI initiatives	Permissions, audit and data boundaries are requirements

BOTTOM-UP COST POOL \$430–860M/year, illustrative — chained from the sourced \$16B mid-market survey (S09) × 27% integration-barrier share (E10) × a labeled 10–20% vertical-share assumption. A cost-of-the-problem ceiling, not a revenue forecast; full chain in research/bottom-up-market-estimate.md.

Willingness-to-pay logic: customers may pay if the product removes measurable coordination work, improves SLA and avoids reopens at a predictable total cost. No interview established an economic buyer, budget threshold, or purchase intent.

06 · CORE PROBLEM

One problem, aimed at the mismatch

JOB STORY when a support agent picks up a case that needs information or action from a second system, they want a single place to see everything relevant — because today that costs 15–25 minutes of manual work per case and leaves duplicate history for the next person to reconstruct.

Two of four interviews (P01, P04) independently describe it — below the interview guide's own four-participant threshold. Leading hypothesis, not proven, aimed directly at the mismatch diagnosed above.

07 · Competitive position — what each incumbent already owns

Public sources, review signals, and two anonymized enterprise interviews were used to build a same-lens comparison across the four named incumbents.

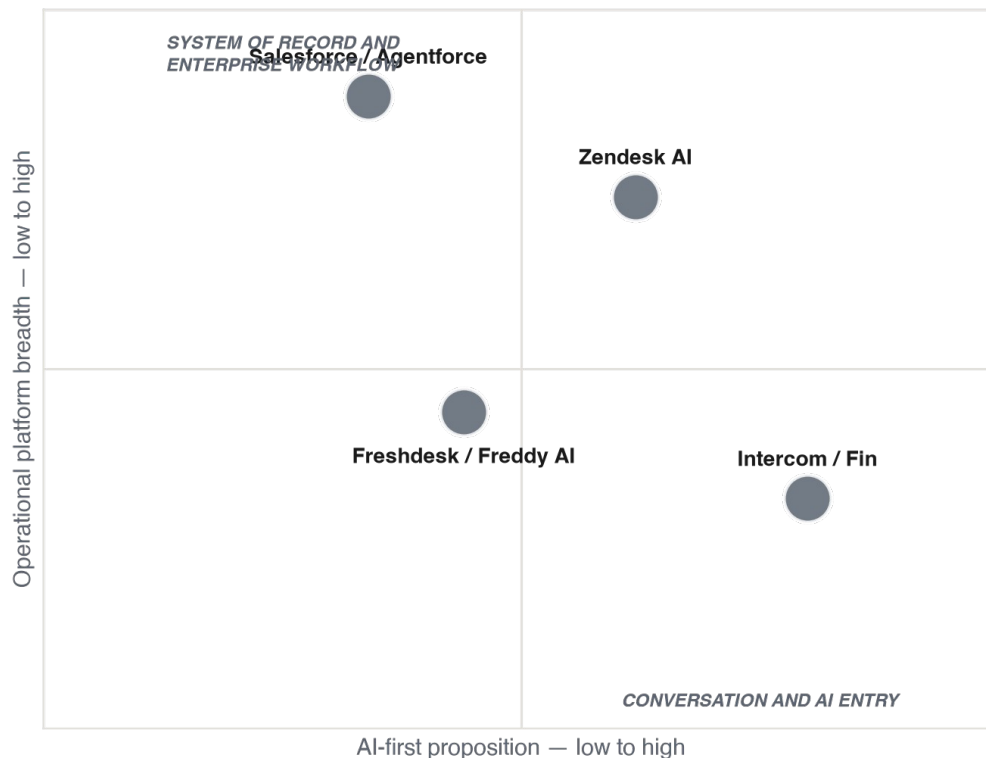
IN	ZD
Intercom / Fin Promise: AI resolution with a clear outcome unit (V1–V3). Weakness: complex workflows and tuning can shift work back into support ops (R1, R2).	Zendesk AI Promise: complete service operations with embedded AI (V4, V5). Weakness: product breadth increases configuration and total-cost complexity (R3, R4).

FD	SF
Freshdesk / Freddy AI Promise: approachable omnichannel service, packaged AI (V6–V8). Weakness: advanced depth and integration reliability lag as teams mature (R5).	Salesforce / Agentforce Promise: governed AI on trusted CRM context (V9–V11). Weakness: time to value and cross-cloud complexity can be high (R6).

Rejected differentiators: “uses AI,” “unifies context,” “integrates with existing tools,” “governed and secure,” “vendor neutral” — necessary, none sufficient.

Entry wedge, what compounds, and where to test each incumbent

PRODUCT	ENTRY WEDGE	VULNERABILITY TO TEST
Intercom / Fin	Standalone, outcome-priced AI agent	Tuning effort, handoff quality, cost predictability
Zendesk AI	Trusted ticketing system of record	Setup effort and workflow-specific resolution quality
Freshdesk / Freddy AI	Ease and accessible price-to-value	Advanced depth and integration reliability as teams mature
Salesforce / Agentforce	CRM context and enterprise governance	Time to value and fit for non-Salesforce stacks



Positions are directional, synthesized from each vendor's own positioning and packaging — not measured scores.

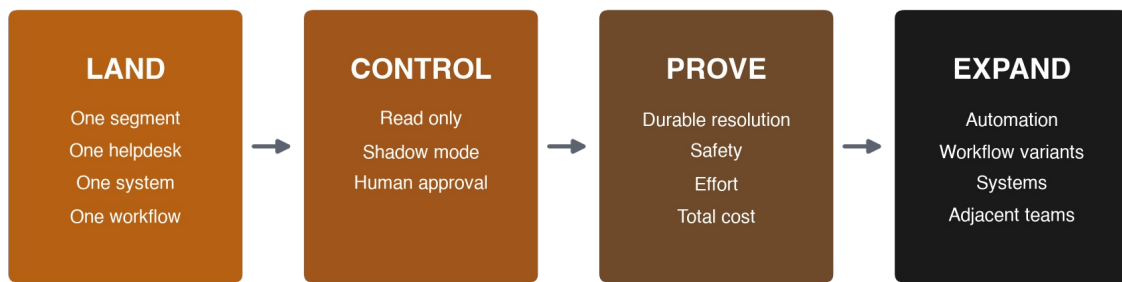
SEVEN CAPABILITIES EVERY INCUMBENT ALREADY CLAIMS AI agents with knowledge-grounded answers; agent assistance and summarization; human handoff and approvals; external integrations and system actions; analytics, evaluation and governance; usage- or outcome-based pricing; compatibility with an existing service stack. Generic AI and integration claims cannot carry the strategy — the entry needs one workflow where the product proves better completion, control, effort, or cost than the incumbent's native AI.

CATEGORY WEDGE TO TEST workflow-specific completeness — assemble permissioned context, show the evidence used, route approval, preserve the full handoff, and write the result back — across a small set of stacks, faster and cheaper than the incumbent's native AI.

08 · PRODUCT, MVP, AND SEQUENCING

The workflow, sequenced by earned trust

The commercial adoption motion has four stages, each a precondition for the next — not four independent options.



Measured workload reduction and reliable outcomes create the pull to expand — a platform mandate on its own does not.

The full eventual workflow has six steps. What changes is when each ships — sequenced to ask IT/security for the least trust first, directly operationalizing the Control stage above.

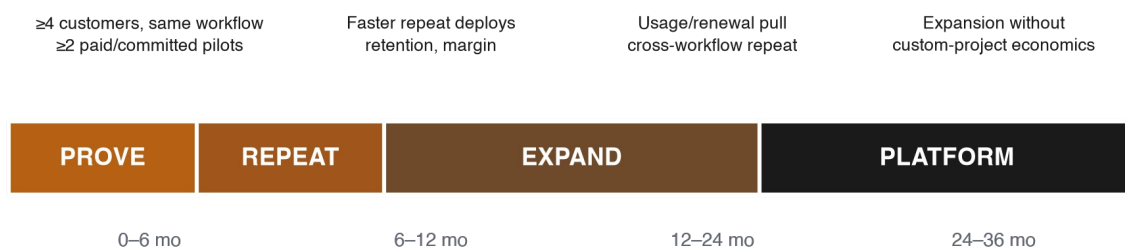
This is where “AI-powered” actually earns its name: an AI agent that perceives, retrieves, reasons, and drafts — with a human as the safety valve wherever the model's own judgment says the risk is high. Only step 2 below is plain deterministic lookup; the rest is the model doing real cognitive work, not automation with extra steps.

STEP	PRODUCT RESPONSIBILITY	WHAT'S ACTUALLY AI	SHIPS AT
1. Detect	Identify a difficult or escalated case in the existing helpdesk	Classifies case difficulty from content, not a static priority flag	Land
2. Resolve identity	Link customer/account across helpdesk and one system of record	Deterministic lookup — the one non-AI step	Land
3. Assemble context	Retrieve recent ticket, account and approval state, read-only, sources shown	Retrieves and synthesizes records across systems into one picture (retrieval-augmented generation)	Land
4. Recommend	Summarize history, gap and next action; draft a customer update	Drafts the next action or update in plain language, grounded in the assembled context	Expand (early)
5. Approve / hand off	Route high-risk steps to the right person with complete context	Judges its own confidence/risk to decide what needs a human first	Expand (early)
6. Write back	Record outcome, source and next step in the system of record	Executes an AI-proposed action once approved — mechanical, not cognitive	Expand (later)

MVP BOUNDARY in scope: one helpdesk, one system of record, one workflow, agent-assist/shadow mode, citations, approval, durable write-back once earned, audit. Not in scope: helpdesk replacement, open-ended autonomous actions, every connector, general chatbot, regulated approval decisions.

09 · ROADMAP

Earn the platform, one gate at a time



HORIZON	GOAL	EVIDENCE GATE
0–6 mo · Prove	One workflow in one segment (Land/Control/Prove above)	≥4 customers show the same workflow; ≥2 paid/committed pilots
6–12 mo · Repeat	Deploy the same workflow faster	Faster repeat deploys; retention; acceptable margin
12–24 mo · Expand	Adjacent workflows for the same team	Usage/renewal pull; repeatable cross-workflow expansion
24–36 mo · Platform	Selected Customer Operations workflows	Expansion without custom-project economics

Quarterly stop rules: narrow or stop if customers prefer incumbent-native AI at acceptable cost; don't automate a step whose data, permission or failure recovery can't be verified; don't add a segment until the first workflow is repeatable and profitable; don't call it a platform until expansion happens without services-heavy customization.

Same categories. One concrete artifact each.

1 Workflow evaluation data Concrete artifact: per-workflow library of correct/refuse/escalate examples. Defeats: competitors starting quality from zero.	2 Reliable action contracts Concrete artifact: versioned, scoped, audited, reversible connectors. Defeats: easy-to-copy idea, hard-to-copy hardening.
3 Operational learning loop Concrete artifact: corrections/reopens become regression tests. Defeats: quality resetting each release.	4 Repeatable deployment Concrete artifact: templates per stack combination. Defeats: slow, costly repeat deployments.
5 Switching cost, trusted ops Concrete artifact: per-customer permission + evaluation profile. Defeats: easy vendor replacement.	

The first three mechanisms were already visible in the competitive teardown; the last two sharpen that list into something each engagement actually produces. None of the five is the model, generic retrieval, or connector-catalogue size — those are copyable with an API key and a weekend, not defensible on their own. No network-effect claim yet.

Land, prove, expand — who and what

MOTION	WHO	OFFER	TRIGGER TO ADVANCE
Land	Head/VP Support or Customer Ops buys; Support Ops operates; IT/security approve	30–60 day pilot for one workflow	Baseline volume, measurable pain, access approved
Control / Prove	Frontline agents and support managers	Shadow/assist workflow, read-only	No rise in reopens, unsafe actions or audit gaps
Expand (early)	Same support team	Adjacent variant or second system	Repeated usage, manager pull
Expand (later)	Customer success / operations	Adjacent workflows, shared controls	Renewal, buyer-backed ROI

METRICS primary: median context-collection minutes per difficult case. Guardrails: reopen rate, incorrect/unauthorized action rate, customer harm, audit completeness, connector failures, CSAT.

Pricing hypothesis: a predictable base subscription plus a capped usage tier tied to workflow volume or verified outcomes. No price set before a durable resolution, reopen window and cost floor are defined.

What has to be true before this scales

RISK	MITIGATION
Incumbents close the gap	Win only with a validated workflow, faster deployment, better economics
Another system increases complexity	Prove reduced total admin effort, not only handle time
Poor context or unsafe action	Read-only first, citations, approval, audit, rollback, safe stop
Custom integration destroys margin	Versioned action contracts, stop rules for bespoke work
Interview evidence is too narrow	Disclose 4/8; treat ICP and workflow as hypotheses
Bottom-up estimate overstates confidence	Vertical-share input labeled an assumption, not fact

REJECT OR NARROW THIS STRATEGY IF customers cannot name one frequent, urgent workflow; IT or security will not permit the required access; the incumbent completes it well enough at lower total cost; no buyer will sponsor a controlled pilot; or the product becomes another destination agents must maintain.

Evidence still missing, and the decision gates

- Buyer interviews across company size and support maturity
- Recent workflow frequency, baseline effort, and failure cost
- A hands-on incumbent comparison and administrator experience
- Security approval, system permissions, and data-boundary requirements
- Pilot sponsorship, willingness to pay, and a full cost model

INTERVIEW DECISION GATE	THRESHOLD	OBSERVED	STATUS
Same repeated workflow	≥4 participants	2	Not met
Measurable impact, leading workflow	≥3 participants	1	Not met
Native tool insufficient	≥3 participants	2	Not met

Strong pilot interest

≥2 participants

0

Not met

FINAL BOUNDARY this document recommends a direction under time and sample constraints. It does not claim a validated ICP, statistically representative demand, a confirmed buyer, willingness to pay, or a proven moat. All four interview decision gates are unmet, and the evidence gaps above are still open.

VIDEO WALKTHROUGH

Video link

A recorded walkthrough (under five minutes) of the decision, evidence, and boundary above.

VIDEO LINK Add the Loom or Google Drive URL here before upload:

Evidence index

General research base

secondary-research-report.md, source-inventory.csv, review-evidence.csv, interview notes P01–P04, and research/bottom-up-market-estimate.md.

Competitive teardown register

research/competitive-teardowns/ — V1–V3 (Intercom pricing, Fin Procedures, outcome definition), V4–V5 (Zendesk AI agents and pricing), V6–V8 (Freshdesk features, pricing, integrations), V9–V11 (Salesforce Service Cloud, Agentforce pricing, guardrails), R1–R2 (Intercom reviews), R3–R4 (Zendesk reviews), R5 (Freshdesk reviews), R6 (Salesforce/Agentforce reviews), I1–I2 (the two enterprise interviews used for cross-system pain examples), H (strategic synthesis), U (explicitly unresolved — see Section 12).

Counts: 91 evidence records → 56 linked sources → 65-source register. Public and interview evidence are stored separately. The competitive register is related but kept distinct — never merged into one ID system.

Submission checklist

- PDF visually checked; no fabricated quotes or participant identities.
- Interview diversity limitation and all unknowns disclosed.
- Competitor capabilities represented as current product claims, not outcome proof.
- Before upload: record the under-five-minute video, paste its working URL in the Video Link section above, regenerate the PDF, and open the link in a private browser window.